



Assignment: seminar reflection report

Author
Ali Adrian Nasrat

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Seminar Reflection

1 Seminar 1-4

1.1 Seminar 1

During Seminar 1, I realised how differently system maintenance can be understood depending on the author or the framework. What stood out most in the discussion was the contrast between Rigg's early, more operational view and Edward's broader definition, which included improvements and adaptation. In my group, we talked about how Nordström and Welanders connected maintenance to business value, which made me think more about the strategic role of maintenance rather than just the technical aspects.

A key takeaway for me was that system maintenance is not a single, fixed activity. Instead, it can mean everything from daily operational tasks to long-term strategic adjustments. This was reinforced by listening to other groups compare different authors. It helped me understand that system maintenance has always been defined differently depending on the time and context.

Another important point for me was how the seminar discussion highlighted the link between maintenance and IT service management. Before, I mainly thought of maintenance as "keeping things running". After the seminar, I started to see it as an ongoing process that must evolve together with business and customer needs. This was something I hadn't fully grasped from just reading the texts.

In short, the seminar helped me broaden my perspective. My original understanding was mostly technical, but through the group reflection I learned to see system maintenance as a dynamic process that supports both stability and development in organisations.

1.2 Seminar 2

During Seminar 2, I learned how different IT service management frameworks approach the same challenges in unique ways. Listening to all the groups, I realised that while the goal of

these frameworks is similar, to ensure that IT services support business needs, the structure, terminology and focus can differ quite a lot.

My key takeaway was that frameworks are not meant to be used in isolation but can complement each other. For example, ITIL 4, provides a very flexible and value-focused approach, while COBIT emphasizes governance and control. Hearing about FitSM, which is a lightweight framework, also showed me that not every organisation needs the full complexity of ITIL or COBIT, smaller organisations can benefit from something simpler. I also found it interesting how ITIL 3, was compared with ITIL 4, highlighting how the newer version emphasizes practices and continual improvement rather than a rigid process. The Swedish pm3 model was new to me, and I learned that it connects IT management more directly to portfolio and project governance, which is especially relevant in public sector organisations.

For my comparison, I will focus on ITIL 4 and COBIT. ITIL4, according to Axelos Limited (2019), is built around the Service Value System, where guiding principles, practices and continual improvement work together to create value. Its strength is flexibility and adaptability, which makes it suitable for organisations dealing with rapid change and digital transformation. COBIT, on the other hand, is described by ISACA (2019) as a governance and management framework that focuses more on ensuring that IT processes align with business objectives and regulatory requirements. Where ITIL 4 emphasizes service delivery and improvement, COBIT emphasizes accountability, control and performance measurement.

The key difference between them is that ITIL 4 is more operational and practice-oriented, focusing on how services are designed, delivered and improved, while COBIT is more governance-oriented, ensuring that IT is managed at the highest level in alignment with business strategy. Together, they can complement each other, ITIL 4 guiding the practical “how” of service management, and COBIT ensuring the “why” and “to what end” from a governance perspective.

Overall, the seminar helped me understand the organisations often need to draw from multiple frameworks depending on their size, maturity and industry. No single framework provides all the answers, but together they give managers and teams a wide set of tools to balance governance, service delivery and continuous improvement.

1.3 Seminar 3

During Seminar 3, I developed a much clearer understanding of the operational level within IT service management and how these day-to-day practices connect to each other. As mentioned during the seminar, all presentations together created a complete picture of the service life cycle from the user’s first contact with the service desk to the deployment of new

releases. One of my key takeaways was how crucial coordination and communication are between these practices. For example, an incident may trigger a problem investigation, which in turn may lead to a change request and eventually a release. I also realised that these processes are not isolated. Their effectiveness depends on how information flows across teams. Before the seminar I viewed them as separate routines, but after the discussions, I started to see them as an integrated operational ecosystem that ensures stability and quality in IT services.

Incident Management aims to restore normal service operation as quickly as possible to minimise business impact (Axelos Limited, 2019). The practice focuses heavily on prioritising incidents according to their urgency and business impact, and on maintaining clear communication with users throughout the process. As Thejendra (2014) notes, good incident management not only fixes issues faster but also improves customer perception by keeping users informed.

Change Enablement ensures that changes are evaluated, authorised and implemented with minimal risk to ongoing services (Axelos Limited, 2019). The practice differentiates between standard, normal, and emergency changes. Standard changes are pre-approved and low risk, normal changes require risk assessment and authorisation, and emergency changes handle urgent fixes. As discussed during the seminar, this structured approach prevents uncontrolled changes that might cause instability, but if applied too rigidly, it can slow innovation.

Service Configuration Management provides accurate and reliable information about the configuration of services, infrastructure, and their relationships (Axelos Limited, 2019). The data is maintained in a configuration management database (CMDB) or system (CMS). During the seminar, we discussed how this practice supports almost every other one, because knowing exactly what components exist and how they are connected allows faster troubleshooting and better risk evaluation. However, Thejendra (2014) points out that keeping configuration data requires continuous effort and discipline, and outdated data can undermine the entire process.

Release Management plans, schedules and controls the movement of releases to test and live environments (Axelos Limited, 2019). Its purpose is to ensure that new or changed services are delivered successfully. Proper release management reduces operational risk and ensures quality, but poor coordination with change or testing activities can delay deployments or introduce new errors (Thejendra, 2014).

Finally, the Service Desk acts as the single point of contact between users and the service provider (Axelos Limited, 2019). As mentioned during the seminar, its role is not only to log and escalate incidents but also to maintain effective communication and provide sense of

accountability. A well-functioning service desk contributes directly to user satisfaction, but if understaffed or poorly integrated with other practices, it can become a bottleneck (Thejendra, 2014).

When reflecting on the advantages and disadvantages of these practices, some clear patterns emerged. Incident Management and Problem Management work best when they operate together, the first ensures quick recovery when issues occur, while the second focuses on finding and removing the underlying causes (Axelos Limited, 2019). This combination provides both immediate stability and long-term improvement. Change Enablement and Release Management bring structure and control to how updates are planned and implemented, reducing risks and improving predictability. However, if the approval process becomes too complex, it can slow down progress and reduce flexibility (Thejendra, 2014). Service Configuration Management supports all other practices by providing visibility and traceability across systems, but maintaining accurate information can require significant effort and resources. Finally, the Service Desk as mentioned plays a central role in communication between users and IT organisation. It adds great value by coordinating actions and maintaining user trust, though it can sometimes face challenges with workload and response times. Overall, the seminar helped me understand how these operational practices depend on each other to maintain a balance between responsiveness, control, and service quality in daily IT operations.

1.4 Seminar 4

During Seminar 4, I gained a deeper understanding of the tactical level within IT service management and how these practices connect to the operational ones we discussed earlier. As mentioned during the seminar, the tactical level is about planning, control and coordination, it sets the direction and conditions for the operational activities to function effectively. While the operational practices handle incidents, changes and releases daily, the tactical practices ensure that IT services are aligned with business goals, perform reliably, and can continue even under challenging circumstances. One key takeaway for me was how much these practices depend on good communication between IT and the wider organisation. I also found it interesting that several of these practices, like Information Security Management and Supplier Management, go far beyond technical IT issues and require strong management and leadership skills.

Service Level Management (SLM) ensures that IT services meet agreed upon business expectations through clear service level agreements (SLAs) and ongoing dialogue with stakeholders (Axelos Limited, 2019). Its main goal is to maintain a shared understanding of service quality and performance. As the ITIL practice guide explains, SLM involves defining measurable targets, monitoring actual performance, and reporting deviations. It bridges the

gap between technical delivery and business outcomes by turning customer expectations into operational objectives.

Availability Management focuses on ensuring that IT services and infrastructure can meet current and future demand in a cost-effective way (Axelos Limited, 2019). This includes monitoring usage, analysing trends and forecasting future requirements. As discussed during the seminar, this practice is not just about having enough capacity, but about optimising performance and balancing cost against quality. According to Thejendra (2014), effective capacity management requires collaboration between technical teams and business planners to align resources with changing priorities.

Service Continuity Management focuses on maintaining essential IT services during and after major disruptions (Axelos Limited, 2019). It involves risk assessment, continuity strategies and testing recovery plans to ensure that critical services can be restored within agreed timeframes. During the seminar, it became clear how this practice complements Availability Management, availability handles minor interruptions, while continuity prepares for large-scale failures such as data centre outages or cyberattacks. Both practices depend heavily on planning and regular testing.

Supplier Management ensures that external suppliers and partners deliver value that aligns with the organisation's objectives (Axelos Limited, 2019). It covers selecting suppliers, negotiating, managing contracts and maintaining relationships to ensure consistent performance. As mentioned in the seminar, the practice is not only about enforcing contracts but also about collaboration and communication. Poor supplier management can lead to service gaps or unexpected costs, while strong partnerships can significantly improve service quality and innovation.

Information Security Management (ISM) protects the organisation's information assets by managing risks related to confidentiality, integrity and availability (Axelos Limited, 2019). It involves developing policies, conducting risk assessments, controlling access and monitoring for threats. The seminar discussion reinforced how ISM underpins all other practices, it builds trust with customers, ensures compliance with standards such as ISO/IEC 27001, and supports business continuity. As Thejendra (2014) notes, effective security management requires both technical defences and human awareness, since people often represent the weakest link.

When reflecting on the advantages and disadvantages of the practical practices, several themes stood out. Service Level Management and Supplier Management help build transparency and accountability between IT and business units, but they can become time-consuming if too many contracts are tracked simultaneously (Axelos Limited, 2019). Availability, Capacity and Continuity Management together create a strong foundation of

stability and resilience, their challenge lies in forecasting accurately and securing sufficient resources for preventive measures (Thejendra, 2014). Information Security Management adds protection and trust but must constantly adapt to new threats which can be costly and complex. Overall, the seminar helped me understand that tactical practices act as a management layer that connects long-term planning with daily operations. They provide structure, predictability and alignment with business goals, but they also require continuous communication and a balance between control and flexibility.

1.5 Reflection of seminar 1-4

Looking back at all four seminars, I can clearly see how my understanding of system maintenance and IT service management evolved from a technical view to a more holistic and strategic one. In the beginning, during Seminar 1, my idea of system maintenance was mostly limited to keeping systems up and running, fixing issues when they occur and ensuring stability. As mentioned during the seminar, hearing how different authors defined maintenance helped me realise that the concept has changed significantly over time. Riggs (1969) focused mainly on technical upkeep, while Edwards (1984) introduced a more integrated view that included adaptation and improvement. This broader understanding shifted my perspective from maintenance as a reactive activity to seeing it as a continuous and planned process that support long-term organisational goals.

In Seminar 2, my thinking expanded even more when comparing frameworks like ITIL 4, COBIT, ITIL 3 and pm3. Presenting ITIL 4 with my group helped me understand how modern ITSM frameworks are not just about processes but about creating value through collaboration and continual improvement (Axelos Limited, 2019). Listening to other groups, I realised that each framework has its own focus, COBIT on governance, FitSM on simplicity and pm3 on public-sector alignment. This comparison taught me that frameworks are not competing alternatives, but complementary tools that organisations can combine depending on their needs. I also noticed how ITIL 4 places much more emphasis on flexibility than earlier models.

In Seminar 3, the focus on the operational level gave me deeper appreciation for the daily work that keeps IT services functioning. I learned that practices like Incident Management, Problem Management and the Service Desk form the backbone of user experience and operational stability (Axelos Limited, 2019). As mentioned during the seminar, I found it particularly insightful to see how the practices connect to each other, for example, an incident may trigger a problem investigation, which might then result in a change request. One thing that challenged me was understanding how to maintain speed and flexibility while still following structured processes. I learned that this balance is what makes operational distinction possible, being fast but not chaotic, and being structured but not slow.

Seminar 4 then tied everything together by introducing tactical level, where planning, coordination and tactical alignment take place. It became clear to me that tactical practices like Service Level Management, Availability Management, Capacity and Performance

Management, Continuity Management, Supplier Management and Information Security Management (Axelos Limited, 2019) act as the management layer above the operational ones. They set the rules, goals and boundaries that make operational work effective. For example, Service Level Management defines what “good service” means, while the Service Desk ensures that this is delivered in practice. Information Security Management, which was my assigned practice, gave me a strong sense of how interconnected these levels are, tactical security policies only work if operational staff apply them consistently.

Across all seminars, my biggest insight has been how independent the tactical and operational levels are. Tactical processes provide structure and governance, while operational ones bring execution and immediate results. Without tactical planning, operations lack direction, without effective operations, tactical goals remain theoretical. From a management perspective, I now understand that leadership in ITSM is for the most part about balancing these two levels, making sure there is enough control and stability without losing flexibility and innovation. I also learned that most challenges come from communication gaps between these levels, such as unclear priorities, unrealistic targets or missing feedback.

Another important reflection is how ITSM frameworks and practices go beyond technology. They are really about people, processes and collaboration. What surprised me throughout the seminars is skills like communication, trust and coordination are just as crucial as technical expertise. This became especially clear when discussing Supplier Management and Service Level Management, which rely on relationships and negotiation as much as they do on performance. It also made me realise that future IT professionals must understand both the technical and organisational sides of service management.

Looking ahead, I believe this learning experience will influence how I approach IT projects and maintenance in my future career. I will be more aware of the need to align technical work with business objectives, communicate clearly across teams and continually look for ways to improve processes rather than just maintain them. In a broader sense, I also see how ITSM frameworks contribute to organisational resilience and even to society, by making IT services more reliable and secure. Overall, these seminars have changed my perspective on system maintenance and ITSM from something purely operational to something strategic and continuously evolving.

2 ITSM from a management perspective

From a management perspective, IT service management (ITSM) is not only about technical processes. It is mainly about creating coordination between different levels in an organisation so that IT can support business goals effectively. The tactical level focuses on planning, control and improvement, while the operational level handles the daily work that delivers IT services (Axelos Limited, 2019). Good management connects these two levels and makes sure that strategies are turned into real results. Without this connection, even well-designed processes may not deliver value.

In ITIL 4, this relationship is very clear. Tactical practices like Service Level Management and Capacity and Performance Management set the goals and standards that define what “good service” means. Operational practices such as Incident Management and Change Enablement then make sure those goals are achieved in daily work. For example, Service Level Management might set a target that most incidents should be solved within a few hours, and Incident Management ensures the right routines and people are in place to make that happen (Axelos Limited, 2019). This shows how tactical decisions guide operational actions.

For managers, one of the hardest tasks is to find the right balance between control and flexibility. Too many rules and approvals can slow down progress, while too little structure can lead to mistakes and instability. The Change Enablement practice (called Change Management in earlier versions of ITIL) is a good example of this. It reduces risks by requiring approval for changes, but if the process becomes too slow, it can stop innovation. The same goes for Information Security Management, it creates important policies for protecting information, but it also depends on employees to follow those policies in their daily work (Thejendra, 2014). Managers therefore need to make sure that policies are realistic and that people understand why they are important.

Another important part of ITSM from a management point of view is communication and trust. During the seminars, I learned that success of ITSM depends a lot on how well people share information between teams and levels. For example, Supplier Management needs both clear contracts and good communication between staff and suppliers. If that connection is weak, small problems can grow and cause service failures or extra costs. Managers play a key role in creating an open, cooperative environment where teams and partners work together instead of independently.

The idea of continual improvement links the two levels. Tactical management identifies what can be improved, and operational teams provide the experience and feedback to make it happen. This is one of the main principles of ITIL 4, progress, step-by-step, and learn from feedback (Axelos Limited, 2019). For managers, this means not only planning and measuring

but also listening and adapting. It also means understanding the human side of ITSM, motivation, stress, teamwork and learning.

In summary, managing ITSM is about connecting planning and execution in a balanced way. The tactical levels set direction, policies and long-term goals. The operational level carries them out and provides feedback from real situations. When these two levels work together, IT services become stable, secure and continuously improved. The main challenge for managers is to find the right balance between structure and flexibility, so that IT can remain reliable while still adapting to new needs.

2.1 Linking tactical and operational practices

One of the main lessons I have learned from this course is that tactical and operational practices are deeply connected and constantly influence each other. The tactical level provides direction, structure and measurable goals, while the operational level turns those goals into concrete actions. Without tactical planning, operations lack focus, without operational feedback tactical decisions risk becoming unrealistic or outdated (Axelos Limited, 2019). From a management perspective, this link is what makes IT service management challenging and effective.

For example, Service Level Management at the tactical level defines what level of quality and responsiveness the organisation should deliver. This information is then used by Incident Management and the Service Desk at the operational level to plan resources, set priorities and communicate with users. When performance data from incidents is reported back to Service Level Management, it helps managers evaluate whether the targets are realistic or if service agreements need to be adjusted. This two-way communication ensures that goals remain achievable and aligned with real-world performance.

Another example is the connection between Change Enablement and Release Management at the operational level, and Capacity and Performance Management at the tactical level. Tactical planning ensures that the organisation has enough capacity to support new releases and system changes, while operational teams execute those releases safely and efficiently. If communication fails between these levels, the result can be failed updates or downtime. A manager's role is to maintain this link by ensuring clear planning, coordination and risk assessment before any major changes take place.

Similarly, Information Security Management operates mostly at the tactical level through making policies and risk assessment, but it relies heavily on operational teams to apply these rules in their daily work (Thejendra, 2014). Security procedures such as access control,

password management and incident reporting are handled operationally, but their effectiveness depends on strategic guidance from the tactical side. This relationship highlights how security is an operational responsibility.

From a management point of view, the interaction between these levels also supports continual improvement. Tactical managers analyse reports and feedback from operational teams to identify where improvements are needed. At the same time, operational staff rely on tactical decisions to prioritize their work and gain the resources they need. The cycle of planning, executing, reviewing and improving only works if both levels communicate openly and consistently (Axelos Limited, 2019).

In practice, this connection can be difficult to manage. If tactical decisions are made without understanding the daily operations, employees may feel disconnected or overburdened. On the other hand, if operational teams work without considering tactical goals, their actions may not contribute to the organisation's overall strategy. Managers must therefore act as bridges between these levels, ensuring that long-term objectives are supported by practical workflows, and that feedback from the operational level continuously shapes future planning.

In conclusion, the link between tactical and operational practices is what keeps IT service management functioning as a complete system. The tactical level sets the direction and priorities, while the operational level puts those plans into action and provides real feedback from daily work. Neither level can succeed on its own, they rely on each other to maintain stability and progress. From a management perspective, the key challenge is to keep this connection strong by encouraging communication, understanding and practical limitations, and ensuring that long-term goals remain realistic. When this balance is achieved, IT services become not only efficient and secure, but also adaptable to change and aligned with the organisation's overall purpose.

2.2 Management perspectives: pros, cons and challenges between levels

When looking at ITIL 4 from a management perspective, the framework has both strong advantages and practical challenges. Its main strength is that it connects planning with daily work in a structured way (Axelos Limited, 2019). The tactical levels set clear goals and service standards, while the operational level carries them out through established practices. This link helps managers ensure that IT services are reliable, measurable and aligned with business needs. Another strength is ITIL 4's focus on continual improvement, which allows organisations to adapt and evolve over time instead of staying static.

At the same time ITIL 4 can also be demanding. Some practices, such as Change Enablement and Configuration Management, can become too detailed and time-consuming if not managed

carefully (Thejendra, 2014). This can lead to delays or frustration among staff. Smaller organisations might also find it difficult to apply all practices due to limited time or resources. The main risk is that the framework becomes more about following processes than achieving real improvement.

From a management point of view, the biggest challenge is keeping a healthy balance between control and flexibility. Tactical managers must make sure goals and processes are realistic, while operational teams need to communicate what works and what doesn't. When these levels are out of sync, efficiency and motivation often suffer. Good communication and mutual understanding are therefore key.

In summary, ITIL 4 gives managers a strong foundation of organizing and improving IT services, but it requires leadership and cooperation to work well. The tactical level provides direction and structure, while the operational level delivers results and feedback. When both sides support each other, IT services become more stable, effective and aligned with the organisation's goals.

2.3 Personal reflection

What stands out to me the most after completing these seminars is how much my way of thinking has developed, not only about IT service management, but also about how I approach learning and teamwork in general. I've realised that understanding frameworks and processes is important, but what really makes a difference is how we apply them in real situations with people.

Throughout the course, I've become more aware of how easily technical work can lose sight of human factors. Listening to classmates, sharing experiences, and reflecting together helped me see how communication, motivation and empathy are just as vital as efficiency or structure. I've started to think more about how people work within a system, not just what the system does. That shift made me appreciate management as something human, about building trust and clarity, not just setting rules.

This course has also made me reflect on the kind of professional I want to become. I see myself as someone who enjoys problem-solving and structure, but I've learned that real progress often comes from listening and adapting. I want to work in environments where collaboration and continuous improvement are valued, and where communication between teams is open and honest.

On a personal level, I've gained more patience and perspective. Before, I sometimes got frustrated when systems or routines didn't work as expected. Now, I tend to think why they

might not be working, what process, communication or leadership issue could be behind it. That mindset has made me calmer and more analytical, which I think will help me a lot in the future roles that require both technical and interpersonal skills.

Overall, these seminars have been more than just an academic exercise. They've helped me understand how much learning happens through dialogue, reflection and connecting ideas to personal experience. I'm leaving this course with a stronger sense of curiosity and clearer picture of how I want to contribute, by combining structure with empathy, and by seeing IT service management not just as a framework, but to build trust, value and improvement in any organisation.

2.3.1 Reflection on tactical and operational practices

Before this course, I didn't give much thought to how tactical and operational practices connect in daily work. I used to think of them as two separate areas, one focused on planning and management, and the other on technical execution. It wasn't until we started discussing them side by side in the seminars that I realised how dependent they really are on each other. Tactical processes don't mean much if the people doing the work don't understand or agree with them, and operational teams can't be effective if they don't have a clear direction from above.

What changed most for me was understanding that this connection isn't just about hierarchy, it's about communication and feedback. I had assumed that most decisions came from the top, but now I see that valuable insight often comes from the bottom, from those handling incidents, changes and users directly. The best managers seem to be those who listen to their teams and use that feedback to shape strategies and goals. This made me think differently about leadership in general, it's not about control, but about creating a bond where both levels support each other.

Another insight I gained is that the relationship between these levels is what keeps IT services both stable and adaptable. The tactical level provides direction and structure, while the operational level tests those ideas. When something doesn't work, it's a signal for both sides to adjust, not just for the team on the ground, but also for management. The dynamic interaction is what makes IT service management feel like an ongoing system rather than a set of rules.

Personally, I've also realised that I'm drawn to this middle space between planning and execution. I like understanding how decisions are made but also how they play out in practice. The seminar showed me that being able to "translate" between tactical and operational thinking is a valuable skill. It requires both analytical understanding and empathy, knowing how people work, what challenges they face and how goals can be adjusted without losing focus.

In my perspective, the key is not deciding which one is more important, but making sure they stay connected through open communication, realistic planning and shared responsibility. That's something I'll carry with me, not just as knowledge about ITSM, but as a mindset for how collaboration should work in any organisation.

2.3.2 Insights and implications

Writing this reflection and analysing the different aspects of IT service management has made me realise that ITSM is not just a framework or a collection of processes, it's a way of thinking about how people, systems and organisations work together. In practice, ITSM is about creating structure without losing flexibility, and about making sure that technical work supports real business value. This balance is much harder to achieve than it looks on paper, and it requires both leadership and collaboration at every level.

One of my biggest insights is that roles and responsibilities in ITSM are more interconnected than I used to think. Tactical managers, operational staff and even external suppliers all depend on each other to succeed. It's not enough for one group to perform well, the real results come when everyone understands how their work fits into the bigger picture. This has changed how I think about leadership. I used to associate leadership mainly with authority and decision-making, but now I see it more as coordination, communication and support. Good leaders help others perform better by creating clarity and removing obstacles.

This reflection has also made me more aware of the future challenges ITSM faces. Technology is developing quickly, and new risks and expectations are constantly emerging. Practices like Information Security Management and Change Enablement will only become more important as organisations depend more on digital services. The challenge will be to maintain structure and governance without slowing down innovation. I think this will require IT professionals who are adaptable, curious and comfortable working across both technical and management areas.

Personally, I now feel more confident about working in environments where strategy and operations meet. I've learned that effective IT service management isn't about perfection, it's about continuous improvement, learning from mistakes and keeping communication open. This mindset will influence how I approach teamwork and problem-solving in the future. I want to contribute to creating systems and processes that not only work well technically but also make life easier for the people who use and maintain them.

In the end, this course shows me that ITSM is as much about people as it is about technology. The most successful organisations seem to be those that understand this, where managers and teams collaborate closely, share feedback and adapt together. That's the kind of culture I hope to be part of and help build in my future career.

3 References

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